Malaria

Transmission

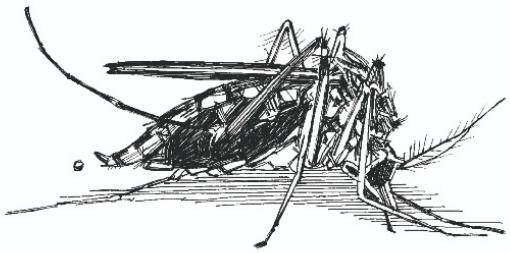
- Mosquito bite
- Mosquitoes that spread malaria usually bite at night, between sunset and sunrise

Symptoms

- Starts with several days of fever, sometimes with nausea, vomiting and headache, back pain, chills/shaking and muscle pain.
- In very severe cases, the patient weakens, becomes unconscious, and suffers from severe lack of iron in the blood (anaemia), and lung and kidney failure.

Prevention

- Sleep under an insecticide-treated bed net at night
- Use insecticide-treated curtains
- Apply indoor residual spraying (IRS)
- Give intermittent prevention therapy (IPT) for infants and pregnant women
- Eliminate mosquito breeding sites by vector control (removing scrub around communities, spraying, etc.)
- Social mobilization and behaviour change communication
- Use of antimalarial medicines (chemoprophylaxis)



A mosquito. A woman and child under a mosquito net.

Vulnerable people

- Children under five years and pregnant women are more vulnerable to severe illness

- People living with HIV
- Displaced populations, migrants and travellers that have not been exposed to malaria before

If an epidemic occurs

- Rapidly detect and refer suspected cases to health facilities for treatment. Early treatment is important especially for children
- Increase community-based surveillance
- Promote use of antimalarial medicines
- Encourage people to sleep at night under an insecticide-treated bed net
- Promote indoor residual spraying (IRS)
- Promote use of insecticide-treated curtains
- Eliminate mosquito breeding sites by vector control (removing scrub around communities, spraying, etc.)

Community-based assessment - questions

Make a map of the community and mark the information you gather on the map. Record other details.

- When did people start to fall sick with malaria?
- How many people have fallen sick with malaria? Where?
- How many people have died? Where?
- How many people live in the affected community or area? How many children under five years of age live in the area? How many pregnant women live in the area?
- How many people are receiving antimalarial medicines?
- Who and where are the vulnerable people? Who is most affected?
- How many children and pregnant women sleep under a bed net at night? Are nets hung up and maintained properly? If people are not using nets, why not?
- What are the community's habits, practices and beliefs regarding indoor spraying?
- How does the community usually remove standing, stagnant water?
- Have the authorities established a vector control programme?
- Where are the local health facilities and services? (Include traditional or community carers.)
- What are the community's habits, practices and beliefs about caring for and feeding sick people? When babies and infants are sick, do women continue to breastfeed them?
- Is a social mobilization or health promotion programme in place?
- Which sources of information do people use most?
- Are rumours or is misinformation about malaria spreading in the community?

Volunteer actions

See the following action tools for more information on what actions to take against malaria:
1 - Community-based surveillance
2 - Community mapping
3 - Communicating with the community
4 - Referral to health facilities
5 - Volunteer protection and safety

19 - Psychosocial support (Psychological first aid (PFA))
23 - Chemoprophylaxis
36 - Vector control
37 - Mosquito nets
38 - Waste disposal and clean-up campaigns
43 - Social mobilization and behaviour change